would have none of it. I do not know if there was any other reason for his refusal to take help from his father-in-law, but Panda put pride and principle before his life. And that should tell the conspiracy theorists something about the IITian getting into ISRO's Vernon team using his father-in-law's Congress connections.

When we all gave up hope of keeping Panda alive, Mademoisille Mary came like an angel. She said she would arrange the money through social security donations and from well-wishers. Many people in the team felt bad that we are forced to take money from a foreign land to save one of our scientist's life; I shared their sentiments, but told everyone that we have no time to waste debating over dignity.

Having said that, I was not yet ready to give up. As a last resort, I wrote a letter again to the joint secretary, this time marking a copy each to the Prime Minister's Office, the Ministry of External Affairs, and the ISRO chairman. We are going ahead with Panda's surgery, I said. I feel sad that we are taking money from our hosts, and this clearly shows how much India cared for its citizens, leave alone its scientists. But I have no choice, I said.

Till now I do not know what happened, there was an immediate response from the department of space, saying that the Government of India would fully fund Panda's treatment. Doctors again warned that the surgery was complicated. The best they could promise was a 50% chance of Panda coming out of the operation theatre alive. Panda came out alive after a successful surgery. On his return to India, he continued with ISRO for a while before moving to the Balasore missile launching facility. He went on to contribute a great deal to India's space programme. He had another child. His wife became close to my wife, and they almost became part of the family.

Thinking of bureaucrats like this joint secretary, I wonder how Indian Civil Service produced two distinctly different sets of people—one blinded by the rule book, and the other who devised ways around rules to see the larger good and national interest, without breaking rules. Seshan belonged